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Impact of Second World War and Partition

My father, Lieutenant Colonel Jaswant Singh Marwah, is a sprightly ninety-one-year-old Second World War veteran. In April 1943, after graduating from the Indian Military Academy, Dehradun, he was commissioned into the Royal Indian Army Service Corps (RIASC). He thus became the first 'afsar', or commissioned officer, in his family. Though he was commissioned in the RIASC, my father's heart was set on serving in the Indian Electrical and Mechanical Engineers (IEME) from the very beginning, as he had majored in subjects like higher mathematics, physics and chemistry for his graduation from the University of Punjab. He was thus happy to get transferred to the IEME in 1948. 'Frankly speaking, I wasn't either enjoying or feeling comfortable doing the assigned duties in the RIASC,' Dad would tell us. It was from the same academy, twenty-one years later, that I would also graduate and get my commission.

In 1944, my father was posted to the Reserve Supply Depot at Karachi Port, after completing the basic young officer's course at Kakul and a few weeks' attachment at the RIASC Centre at Ambala. The Karachi depot stocked rations for the army deployed in the Punjab and the North West Frontier Province, particularly items like tinned fish and milk imported from the UK. He married Jaspal Kaur in December 1944 in Rawalpindi, and took her to Karachi. They were in Karachi for a brief period during the war. My father recounts that he would take my mother out to the sea quite often by motor boat, and they would also go for long walks on the beach. It was exciting for them to be near the sea – it was like a honeymoon posting. However, sadly for them, it lasted only a few months.